the Wall signified more than a formidable structure; it was a social environment to be borrowed for comparative critique.[26]

As artists, activists, and political figures first made sense of Berlin's boundaries by way of American lines of division, conjuring the Wall as an uncanny structure, Freed was distant from such resonances and references, spending his time as an expatriate documentary photographer and traveler across Europe. When the Wall was built, he was in exile and largely tuned out of American culture, interrupted by his encounters at the border. But when he arrived at the Berlin Wall, he, too, sought the transnational parallels between systems and sites of division. His single-shot and Berlin images prompted his return to the United States. They informed his understanding of both the physical divides inscribed into the American landscape and the symbolic resonance of division in historically traumatized German spaces around the potential for exchange.

As a photographer, Freed engaged subjects at the intersection of geopolitics and history. Freed honed his connections between America and divided Germany as a matter of photographic practice and existential questioning. Freed negotiated his own positioning in relation to each of his images: how to, if at all, place himself in the same spaces as his subjects, and how to read the broader landscapes and layers of history that informed their encounters.

Freed's approach was influenced by his admiration of and affiliation with the international photography collective Magnum. Started in 1947 by photographers Henri Cartier-Bresson, Robert Capa, George Rodger, and David "Chim" Seymour, Magnum was formed as a social and aesthetic response to the human catastrophes of World War II. With offices originally in Paris and New York, this group used photography to respond to the traumas of war experienced firsthand by many of its early photographers who were victims or documenters of violence. (The word "magnum" recalls "a gun of a type designed to fire cartridges more powerful than its caliber suggests," patented in 1935.)[27] Magnum members did so by reappropriating several wartime advancements in photographic technology, including the use of portable "mini cameras" and more light-sensitive film, to rapidly restore human connection and nurture new forms of storytelling. They promoted the photographer as "the idiosyncratic mix of reporter and artist," creators who also owned the rights to the photographs they shot and contributed images to